

the emptiness and silence of other venues. Nestled between a railway station and a national highway, with the High-Speed Rail Corporation building on one side, the ground offered quite the view.

The Punjab team's exuberant cheers after every wicket were punctuated by the distant blare of a car horn from vehicles descending the flyover, or occasionally by the louder, coarser horn of a goods train.

Early morning joggers in the area spotted a few familiar faces on the ground and quickly rang up their friends. In no time, a swarm of people had gathered at the periphery, shouting "Surya!" and "Shreyas!"

Despite the absence of Indian



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internationals, the crowd swelled, and by noon, there weren't enough plastic chairs to accommodate everyone. This led to an impromptu and intense game of musical chairs, with fans even trusting IPL scouts to save their seats during washroom breaks! If only they knew.

Anish Pathiyil

For the love of cricket

The timing of the Vijay Hazare Trophy, the national One-Day cricket championship, has often been a subject of debate in recent years due to the way it is scheduled during the season. Nevertheless, the championship remains one of the primary platforms for young talents to catch the attention of national selectors, which motivates these players to excel alongside the stalwarts of Indian cricket. This is

despite the IPL mega auction taking place just a few weeks before the Vijay Hazare Trophy began in early December.

Franchises ensured that big names like Ishant Sharma and Venkatesh Iyer participated in the tournament, delighting fans. Even when rested, these players showed their commitment. Ishant, recovering from an injury, was seen offering valuable tips to young Delhi bowlers during a match against Bihar. Similarly, Venkatesh Iyer, who missed a match due to a back spasm, carried drinks with a smile, embracing the responsibility with enthusiasm. These moments highlighted the spirit of mentorship and teamwork in cricket. The presence of established players like Delhi pacer Navdeep Saini, who approached the game with notable seriousness, served as an important

Team player: India and Delhi pacer Ishant Sharma was spotted carrying drinks during a Vijay Hazare Trophy match against Bihar. V. V. SUBRAHMANYAM

lesson for others in the team. Such gestures, whether sharing advice or demonstrating professionalism, can significantly influence the career trajectories of emerging players in the long term.

While cricketers were busy showcasing their talent — some aiming to secure their places, others attempting comebacks — individuals like former India left-arm spinner S. L. Venkatapathi Raju and Karnataka cricketer K. P. Appanna were seen scouting talent for Delhi Capitals, ensuring the future of Indian cricket remains bright.

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